OPTIONS TO PUNISH PAKISTAN

India has a few options on the table to make Islamabad pay, and pay heavily, for their long-standing support to cross-border terrorism. However, each comes with consequences, and not just for our recalcitrant neighbour



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AIR STRIKES

The obvious reference point is India's air strike in 2019 following the Pulwama attack, where 12 Mirage jets fooled the Pakistan Air Force, made a deep ingress and bombed a JeM camp in Balakot, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, inviting retaliatory air strikes from Pakistan in J&K. The IAF's Rafale jets (*in pic*) are one of the best multirole fighters, so this is an option. India's strike can be at the LeT headquarters in and around Muridke.

Fallout: After the Pahalgam incident, Pakistan is said to have moved more of its air assets to Lahore and Rawalpindi. Its Airborne and Early Warning and Control (AEW&C) aircraft are also watching the Indian airspace.



MISSILE ATTACKS

Instead of mobilising for a conventional conflict, India could target terror launch-pads/ training centres in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir and elsewhere with surface-to-surface short-range tactical missiles like Prithvi, Pralay *(in pic)* and Shaurya, all of which are ideal for hitting strategic targets across the border.

Fallout: Pakistan's terror infrastructure can be in camps in proximity to those of the armed forces. If an Indian missile strike hits a Pak army unit, it will lead to a wider conflagration. Also, the worry is that Pakistan has missiles with tactical nuclear weapons.



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which is outraged at the brutal killing of their countrymen and wants the Modi government to avenge the attacks through military force. India had done exactly that after the terror attacks in Uri in 2016 and in Pulwama in 2019. In Uri, after four Pakistan-backed Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM) terrorists stormed the Indian Army brigade unit on September 18, 2016, killing 19 soldiers, India retaliated strongly. Ten days later, Indian army commandos crossed the Line of Control (LoC) and conducted a series of retaliatory surgical strikes on militant launch-pads and camps, claiming to have killed over 150 militants. In 2019, after a suicide vehicle bomb attack by a JeM operative in Pulwama killed 40 Central Reserve Police Force men, India struck back by sending 12 Mirage 2000 jets into Pakistan territory and bombing the JeM camp in Balakot. It was the first time since the 1971 war that India had deployed its air force for a cross-border strike.

Tilak Devasher, a former senior officer of the Research and Analysis Wing (RAW) and author of several books on Pakistan, says, "Public opinion demands retribution and once you have set the bar so high after the Uri and Pulwama retaliatory strikes, the Modi government will have to act very decisively for people to feel reassured. What manner it should take is for the government to decide but, in this particular case, the more irrational you are, the more effective you are going to be."

While the Modi government has a range of kinetic (military) options, experts emphasise the need for clarity on objectives and outcomes. Lt Gen. Syed Ata Hasnain, who has served extensively in the Valley, says, "Starting from a low calibration of letting the current ceasefire go up in flames, which to my mind will achieve nothing, we have a range of options." Hasnain is clear that the response should go beyond just giving Pakistan a bloody jaw to appease public sentiment.